DDA5001 Homework 2

The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen
Kunyuan Zhong Student ID: 226040255

Problem 1: Concepts and fundamental knowledge

(a) VC dimension. The VC dimension is $d+1$ for affine binary linear classifiers in $\mathbb{R}^d$, where the appended constant feature supplies the intercept. The $d+1$ affinely independent vertices of a simplex can be shattered. The standard upper bound for affine halfspaces rules out shattering $d+2$ points. The feature count d here excludes the constant coordinate.

(b) Test error versus out-of-sample error. For a fixed learned classifier h, its out-of-sample classification error is the population probability

$$E_{\text{out}}(h) = \mathbb{P}_{(x,y)\sim P}\{h(x) \neq y\}.$$

The test error is the observed fraction of mistakes on a finite held-out test sample:

$$E_{\text{test}}(h) = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{j=1}^{m} \mathbf{1}\{h(x_j) \neq y_j\}.$$

It varies with the test sample and estimates the population error; with i.i.d. test examples independent of learning, its expectation conditional on the fixed h equals $E_{\text{out}}(h)$. The two quantities need not be numerically equal.

(c) Gradient descent: statement 2 is false.

1) True. Convexity gives $L(u) \geq L(\theta) + \nabla L(\theta)^\top (u-\theta)$. A zero gradient therefore implies $L(u) \geq L(\theta)$ for every u.

2) False. For $L(\theta) = \theta^2$, one update is $\theta^+ = (1-2\mu)\theta$. If $\mu > 1$ and $\theta \neq 0$, then $L(\theta^+) > L(\theta)$. Convexity alone cannot control an arbitrarily large step.

3) True. For $g = \nabla L(\theta) \neq 0$, differentiability gives $L(\theta - \alpha g) = L(\theta) - \alpha\|g\|^2 + o(\alpha)$. This decreases for sufficiently small positive α.

4) True. The iterate displacement is $\mu\|\nabla L(\theta)\|$ and can be tiny because μ is tiny. For the same quadratic, an arbitrarily small learning rate can give a tiny displacement far from the minimizer 0.

(d) Softmax: statement 3 is false.

1) True. Exponentiation preserves ordering and all classes share the same positive denominator; the sets of maximizers, including ties, coincide.

2) True. Adding c multiplies numerator and denominator by e^c, which cancels.

3) False. Scaling scores changes their differences and typically changes the probabilities. For scores $(0, 1)$, the second probability is $e/(1+e)$; after scaling by 2 it is $e^2/(1+e^2)$. A positive scale preserves the predicted class, but not these probabilities.

4) True. If the true class is y, one-hot cross-entropy reduces to $-\log q_y$.

Problem 2(a): Analytic mean cross-entropy gradient

For one sample, use $z = \Theta^\top x$, $q = \text{softmax}(z)$ and one-hot p with $\sum_j p_j = 1$. Softmax probabilities are strictly positive in exact arithmetic.

Step 1: differentiate cross-entropy.

$$H(p,q) = -\sum_{j=1}^{K} p_j \log q_j, \qquad \boxed{\frac{\partial H}{\partial q_j} = -\frac{p_j}{q_j}.}$$

Step 2: differentiate with respect to the logits. Separating $j = k$ from the other terms in the chain rule gives

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial H}{\partial z_k} &= -\frac{p_k}{q_k} q_k(1-q_k) + \sum_{j\neq k} \left(-\frac{p_j}{q_j}\right)(-q_j q_k) \\ &= -p_k + p_k q_k + q_k \sum_{j\neq k} p_j = -p_k + q_k \sum_j p_j = q_k - p_k.\end{aligned}$$

Hence $\boxed{\nabla_z H = q - p \in \mathbb{R}^K}$.

Step 3: differentiate the parameter columns. Since $z_k = \theta_k^\top x$ and only column θ_k affects z_k,

$$\nabla_{\theta_k} H = x(q_k - p_k), \qquad \boxed{\nabla_\Theta H = x(q-p)^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times K}.}$$

The outer product has features as rows and classes as columns.

Step 4: average over samples.

$$\boxed{\nabla_\Theta L(\Theta) = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i (q_i - \mathbf{1}_i)^\top = \frac{1}{n} X^\top (P - Y).}$$

Here $X \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times d}$ has sample rows; $P = \text{softmax}(X\Theta)$ and $Y \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times K}$ have probability and one-hot rows. The factor $1/n$ corresponds to the mean loss, not a sum loss.

Problem 2(b): Implementation and fixed experiment

The six functions are in `p2/algorithms.py`. Softmax subtracts each row maximum m before exponentiation. Since $e^{z_j - m}/\sum_\ell e^{z_\ell - m} = e^{z_j}/\sum_\ell e^{z_\ell}$, this is the same distribution. The loss uses

$$\log q_j = (z_j - m) - \log \sum_\ell e^{z_\ell - m},$$

then averages $-\sum_j p_j \log q_j$. Thus it avoids $\log(0)$ after probability underflow, without clipping. Training uses the analytic matrix gradient, no autodiff, ready-made optimizer or classifier. All updates return new arrays.

For updates $k = 1, \ldots, 1000$, with $\Theta_0 = \Theta_1 = 0$, $\mu = 0.05$ and $\beta = 0.90$,

$$\begin{aligned}\text{GD:} &\quad \Theta_{k+1} = \Theta_k - \mu \nabla L(\Theta_k), \\ \text{Momentum:} &\quad \Theta_{k+1} = \Theta_k - \mu \nabla L(\Theta_k) + \beta(\Theta_k - \Theta_{k-1}), \\ \text{Nesterov:} &\quad W_k = \Theta_k + \frac{k-1}{k+2}(\Theta_k - \Theta_{k-1}), \quad \Theta_{k+1} = W_k - \mu \nabla L(W_k).\end{aligned}$$

Each update uses exactly one full-training-set gradient. The original framework fixes seed 666, stratified 80/20 splitting after exact deduplication, training-only standardization and an appended constant feature, without regularization. No test observations enter a gradient. Parameters have shapes 65×10 (Digits) and 17×7 (Dry Bean). The recorded iteration is the number of completed updates.

Problem 2(b): Numerical verification before training

Gradient check. The supplied four-sample input, labels and parameter matrix were used:

$$X = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 1 \\ 2 & 0.5 & 1 \\ -1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0.5 & 0.2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad Y = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \Theta = \begin{pmatrix} 0.1 & -0.2 & 0.05 \\ 0.3 & -0.1 & 0.2 \\ 0.02 & 0.1 & -0.1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

For each entry, the central difference is

$$(G_{\text{FD}})_{ab} = \frac{L(\Theta + 10^{-6}E_{ab}) - L(\Theta - 10^{-6}E_{ab})}{2 \times 10^{-6}}.$$

The computed analytic and numerical matrices are, respectively,

$$G_{\text{analytic}} = \begin{pmatrix} -0.0050469778 & -0.4493466297 & 0.4543936075 \\ 0.4507050638 & -0.0919780778 & -0.3587269860 \\ 0.1365728698 & -0.2029764344 & 0.0664035646 \end{pmatrix}$$

$$G_{\text{FD}} = \begin{pmatrix} -0.0050469777 & -0.4493466297 & 0.4543936075 \\ 0.4507050638 & -0.0919780777 & -0.3587269860 \\ 0.1365728699 & -0.2029764343 & 0.0664035645 \end{pmatrix}$$

The maximum entrywise absolute difference, before rounding the displayed matrices, is 1.174011×10^{-10}. This is below 10^{-8} and supports agreement with the mean-loss gradient in part (a).

One accelerated update. Set $\Theta_{\text{previous}} = \Theta - 0.02$ entrywise, $\mu = 0.05$, $\beta = 0.90$, $k = 3$ and $G(A) = 2A$. Momentum evaluates G at the current matrix Θ displayed above and returns

$$\Theta^{+}_{\text{Momentum}} = \begin{pmatrix} 0.1080 & -0.1620 & 0.0630 \\ 0.2880 & -0.0720 & 0.1980 \\ 0.0360 & 0.1080 & -0.0720 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Nesterov uses $(k-1)/(k+2) = 2/5$, so its recorded gradient point is

$$W = \Theta + 0.008 = \begin{pmatrix} 0.1080 & -0.1920 & 0.0580 \\ 0.3080 & -0.0920 & 0.2080 \\ 0.0280 & 0.1080 & -0.0920 \end{pmatrix},$$

and its computed updated parameter is

$$\Theta^{+}_{\text{Nesterov}} = \begin{pmatrix} 0.0972 & -0.1728 & 0.0522 \\ 0.2772 & -0.0828 & 0.1872 \\ 0.0252 & 0.0972 & -0.0828 \end{pmatrix}.$$

These match the separate formula calculations $0.9\Theta + 0.018$ and $0.9(\Theta + 0.008)$. Both gradient points match their expectations exactly in the check; both update discrepancies are 2.776×10^{-17} (rounding), with one gradient call each. Momentum uses the current point and adds the previous displacement afterward. Nesterov extrapolates first and evaluates the gradient at that extrapolated point.

Additional checks. All seven supplied P2 tests passed before the full runs. The loss on logits $(1000, -1000)$ with the second class true is 2000 (expected 2000); zero logits with three classes give $\log 3 = 1.0986122887$. Stability, shift invariance, first-update equality and unchanged inputs also passed. The included `p2/verify.py` prints these numerical checks without downloading a dataset.

Problem 2(b): Digits learning curves

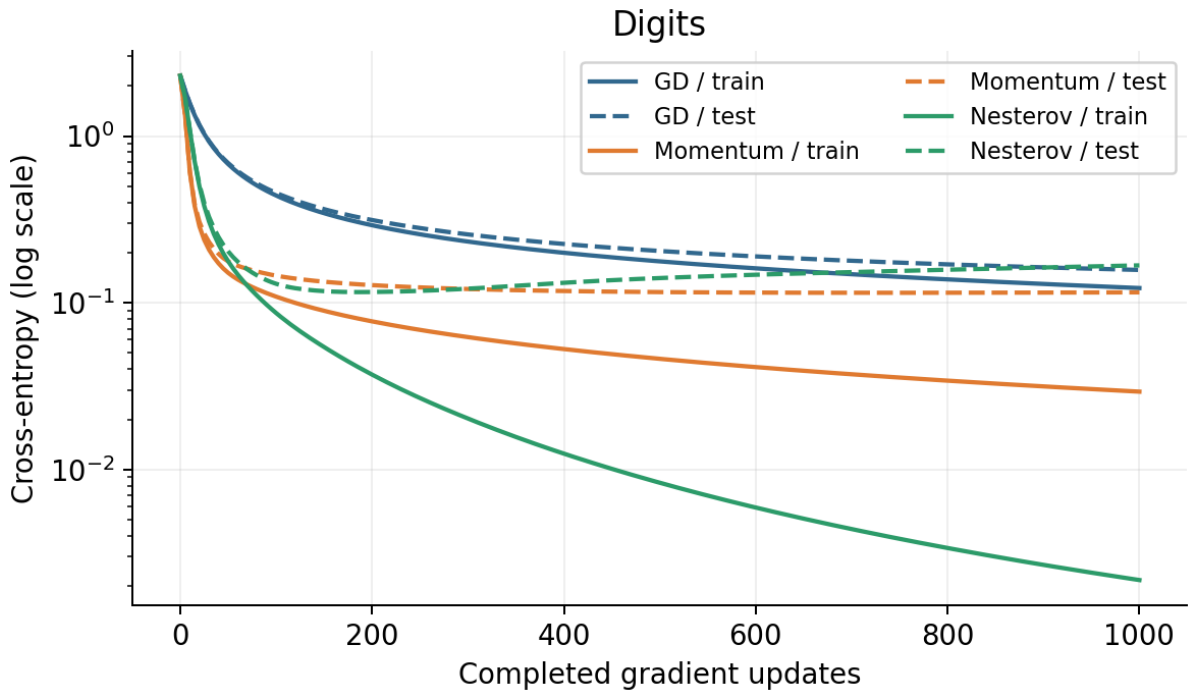


Figure 1: Digits mean cross-entropy on a logarithmic vertical axis. Each of the three methods has a training curve and a test curve.

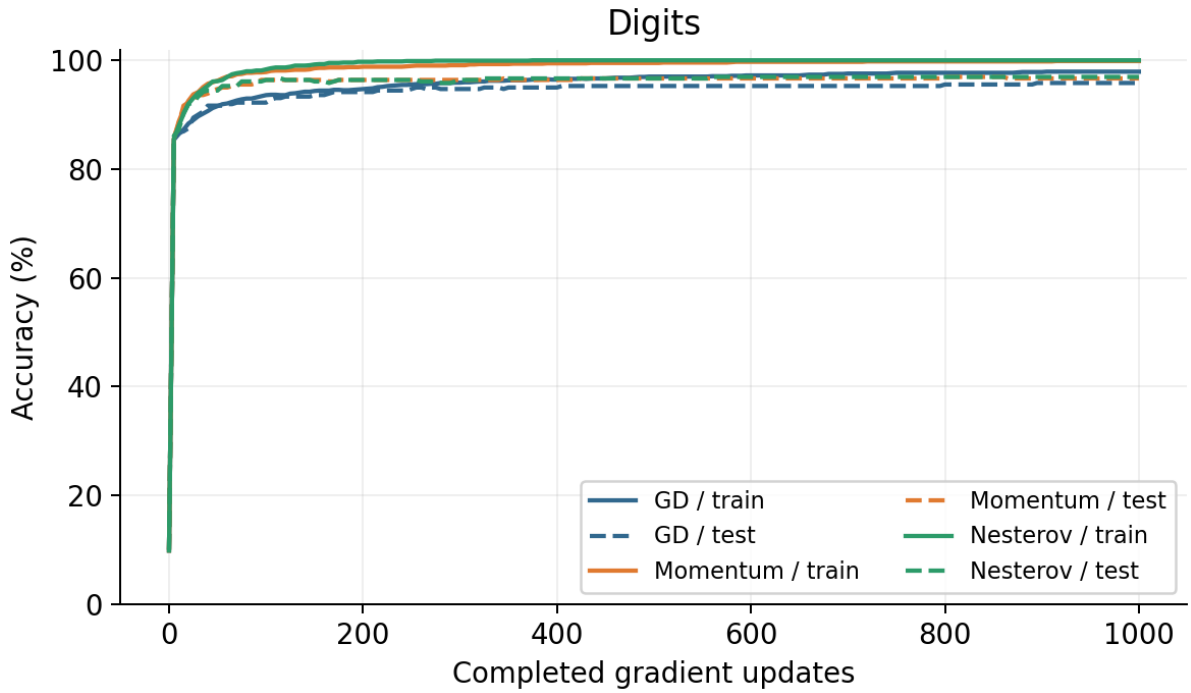


Figure 2: Digits accuracy. Solid lines are training and dashed lines are test. Values are recorded after updates $0, 5, \ldots, 1000$.

Problem 2(b): Dry Bean learning curves

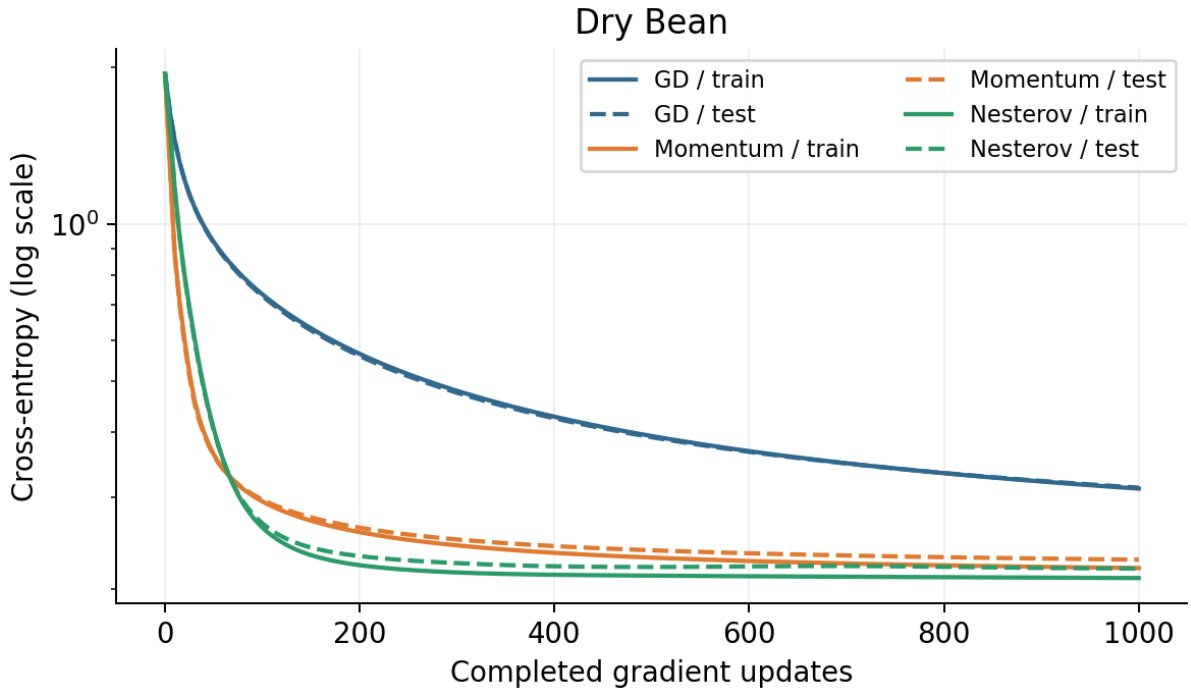


Figure 3: Dry Bean mean cross-entropy on a logarithmic vertical axis, using the same fixed methods and settings as Digits.

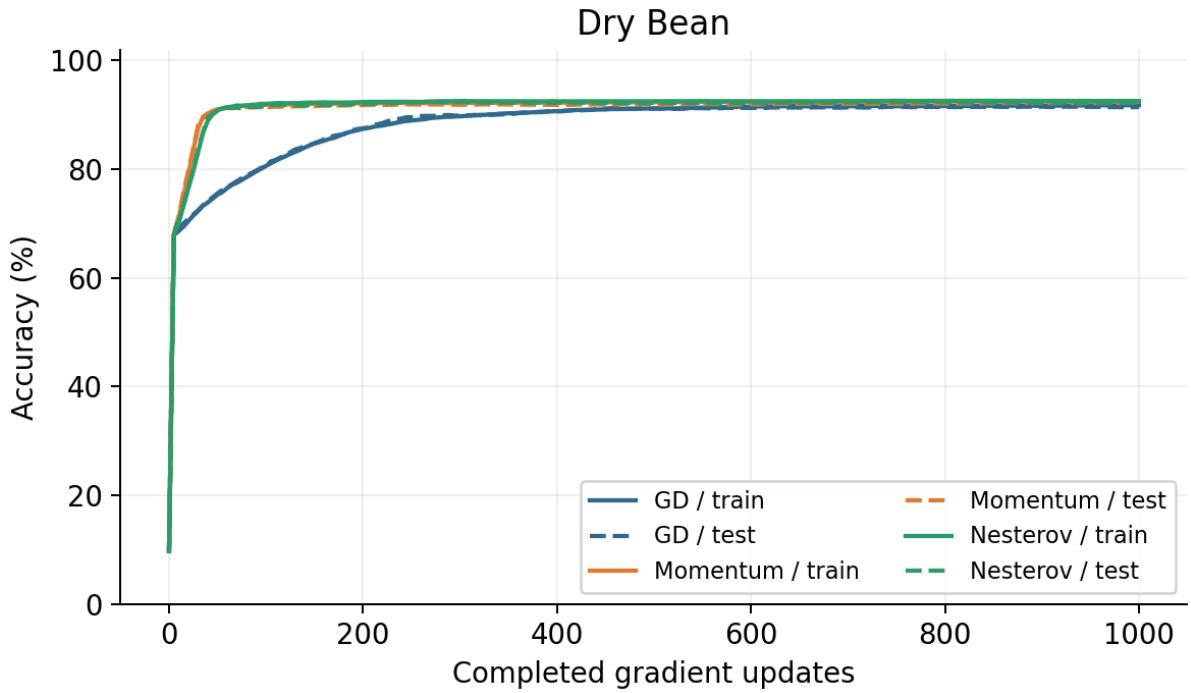


Figure 4: Dry Bean accuracy. Each figure contains all six training/test curves; the held-out set is used only for evaluation.

Problem 2(b): Results and interpretation

Dataset sizes. Digits has 1437 training and 360 test examples, with no exact duplicates removed. Dry Bean has 10834 training and 2709 test examples after removing 68 duplicates (13543 remaining). These sizes and the train/test hashes were recorded by the unmodified framework.

Table 1: Metrics after exactly 1000 updates. CE denotes mean cross-entropy; accuracy is a percentage.

Dataset	Method	Train CE	Test CE	Train acc.	Test acc.
Digits	GD	0.122606	0.157478	97.912%	95.833%
Digits	Momentum	0.029333	0.115559	99.861%	96.667%
Digits	Nesterov	0.002176	0.167670	100.000%	96.944%
Dry Bean	GD	0.311315	0.312644	91.748%	91.399%
Dry Bean	Momentum	0.219241	0.227494	92.431%	92.174%
Dry Bean	Nesterov	0.209742	0.218661	92.524%	92.174%

(i) Which method reduces training loss faster? In these runs, Nesterov eventually reduces training loss fastest, Momentum is next, and GD is slowest on both datasets. At update 100, the training CE values for GD/Momentum/Nesterov are $0.439801/0.108877/0.086856$ on Digits and $0.734252/0.294142/0.262083$ on Dry Bean. The final training losses have the same ordering. This is a comparison at equal gradient-update budgets, rather than a claim that one curve is lower at every early iteration.

(ii) Which method has the best final test metrics? On Digits, Momentum has the lowest test CE (0.115559), while Nesterov has the highest test accuracy (96.944%). Nesterov has the lowest training CE but a higher test CE (0.167670) than both other methods. Accuracy measures only the winning class; CE also penalizes confident incorrect predictions, so their rankings can differ. On Dry Bean, Nesterov has the lowest test CE (0.218661), and Nesterov and Momentum tie for the highest test accuracy (92.174%, exactly the same accuracy before rounding). Thus the lowest-training-loss method is best on test CE for Dry Bean, but not for Digits.

(iii) Is there evidence of overfitting? On Digits, Nesterov's smallest recorded test CE is 0.115969 at update 185; its training CE there is 0.041322. By update 1000, training CE falls to 0.002176 while test CE rises to 0.167670. Momentum has a weaker instance: after its test CE minimum of 0.114851 at update 730, training CE falls from 0.036272 to 0.029333, while test CE increases to 0.115559. The loss curves therefore show a divergence between continued fitting of training examples and held-out log-loss performance. In the last 100 updates, test CE increases by 0.004749 for Nesterov and 0.000392 for Momentum while each training CE decreases.

For Dry Bean, no sustained late training/test loss divergence is observed. All three methods attain their lowest recorded test CE at update 1000, and both losses decrease over the last 100 updates. This does not prove that the models cannot overfit with a different training duration or setting. Test minima above are descriptive observations only; the prescribed final update remains 1000 and no stopping rule or hyperparameter was selected using the test set.

Problem 2(b): AI collaboration case

Decision being checked. This case concerns whether the Nesterov implementation evaluates its gradient at the prescribed lookahead point. The code and numerical checks had already been produced with Codex assistance when the student raised this verification question. The dialogue below is the actual student–Codex exchange, translated from Chinese into English; the original Chinese messages are retained in this chat and the local conversation record. Tool: Codex; no more specific model identifier was displayed.

Student's initial concern and actual prompt.

> "Why does Nesterov evaluate the gradient at the lookahead point, and can the existing $k = 3$ check distinguish an incorrect evaluation point?"

Relevant response excerpt (English translation).

> "Nesterov first uses the previous displacement to form a lookahead point W, then corrects it using the gradient at W; this is the update formula specified in this assignment. Evaluating the gradient at the current parameter Θ instead would give a different update."

Codex then explained the existing prescribed check: $\Theta - \Theta_{\text{previous}} = 0.02$ entrywise, $k = 3$, $\mu = 0.05$, and $G(A) = 2A$. Thus $W = \Theta + (2/5)(0.02) = \Theta + 0.008$ and

$$\underbrace{W - 0.05(2W)}_{\text{correct}} = 0.9\Theta + 0.0072, \qquad \underbrace{W - 0.05(2\Theta)}_{\text{wrong gradient point}} = 0.9\Theta + 0.008.$$

The incorrect result differs by 0.0008 in every entry. Codex reported that the implemented function recorded the point W and that its update differed from the correct formula by only 2.78×10^{-17}. It also explained why a first-step-only check would miss the distinction: the first extrapolation coefficient is zero.

Numerical evidence brought back and focused follow-up. After this response, the student asked (English translation):

> "The result shows a one-step error of only 2.78×10^{-17}, whereas an incorrect evaluation point would differ by 0.0008: is this enough to retain the current code, and what else needs checking?"

This follow-up was selected and submitted by the student from a suggested question in the chat. The numerical evidence was calculated by the verification script, rather than being claimed as a manual student calculation.

Relevant follow-up response and final action. Codex answered that these values support retaining the gradient location, while one check alone does not establish correctness of the whole program. It identified the analytic gradient, update count, one gradient call per update, nonmutation and exclusion of test data from training as further checks. It then reported that all 15 supplied tests passed and a separate Verifier checked other iterations and data leakage and reproduced both complete experiments in a fresh environment, with identical results. Codex's actual concluding decision was (English translation):

> "Therefore I will retain the current code without modification, and include your numerical follow-up and this decision in the AI case."

The code was retained under the student's instruction to complete the assignment. The required matrices and unrounded discrepancies are on page 3 and are regenerated by `p2/verify.py`. The matrix-gradient check gives a maximum difference of 1.174011×10^{-10}, below 10^{-8}; the accelerated-update check uses tolerance 10^{-14}. No bug, student computation, prior student derivation or additional exchange was invented. Assistance with implementation, execution and English drafting is disclosed separately.

Problem 3(a): Least-squares Legendre fits

For degree K, define

$$A_K = \begin{pmatrix} L_0(x_1) & L_1(x_1) & \cdots & L_K(x_1) \\ L_0(x_2) & L_1(x_2) & \cdots & L_K(x_2) \\ \vdots & \vdots & & \vdots \\ L_0(x_n) & L_1(x_n) & \cdots & L_K(x_n) \end{pmatrix}, \quad w^{(K)} = \begin{pmatrix} w_0 \\ w_1 \\ \vdots \\ w_K \end{pmatrix}, \quad y = \begin{pmatrix} y_1 \\ y_2 \\ \vdots \\ y_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then $A_K \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times(K+1)}$, $w^{(K)} \in \mathbb{R}^{K+1}$ and $y \in \mathbb{R}^n$. In particular, A_2 has rows $(1, x_i, (3x_i^2-1)/2)$ and A_{10} has rows $(L_0(x_i), \ldots, L_{10}(x_i))$.

A nonzero linear combination of these basis polynomials has degree at most K, so it cannot vanish at $K+1$ distinct inputs. Thus the assumed $n \geq K+1$ distinct samples imply full column rank. Differentiating the mean squared training error gives

$$\nabla_w \left(\frac{1}{n} \|A_K w - y\|_2^2 \right) = \frac{2}{n} A_K^\top (A_K w - y) = 0.$$

Since $A_K^\top A_K$ is positive definite, the unique minimizer is

$$\boxed{\widehat{w}^{(2)} = (A_2^\top A_2)^{-1} A_2^\top y, \qquad \widehat{w}^{(10)} = (A_{10}^\top A_{10})^{-1} A_{10}^\top y.}$$

These inverses describe the mathematical solution. The implementation uses `numpy.linalg.lstsq(A, y, rcond=None)` to solve it numerically without forming the normal-equation inverse. For batched labels, each column is fitted independently using the same A_K. No oracle target coefficients enter fitting.

Problem 3(b): Analytic out-of-sample error

Let $c_q = a_q/C_Q$ for $0 \leq q \leq Q_g$ and $c_q = 0$ above Q_g. Similarly set $\widetilde{w}_q = w_q$ for $q \leq K$ and 0 above K. With $M = \max(K, Q_g)$,

$$f_K(x) - g(x) = \sum_{q=0}^{M} (\widetilde{w}_q - c_q) L_q(x).$$

Using density $1/2$ for $x \sim \text{Uniform}[-1,1]$ and the supplied orthogonality,

$$\begin{aligned} E_{\text{out}}(f_K) &= \frac{1}{2} \sum_{q=0}^{M} \sum_{j=0}^{M} (\widetilde{w}_q - c_q)(\widetilde{w}_j - c_j) \int_{-1}^{1} L_q(x) L_j(x)\, dx \\ &= \frac{1}{2} \sum_{q=0}^{M} (\widetilde{w}_q - c_q)^2 \frac{2}{2q+1} = \boxed{\sum_{q=0}^{M} \frac{(\widetilde{w}_q - c_q)^2}{2q+1}.} \end{aligned}$$

Thus, with empty sums equal to zero and $c_q = 0$ when $q > Q_g$,

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} E_{\text{out}}(f_2) &= \sum_{q=0}^{2} \frac{(\widehat{w}_q^{(2)} - c_q)^2}{2q+1} + \sum_{q=3}^{Q_g} \frac{c_q^2}{2q+1}, \\ E_{\text{out}}(f_{10}) &= \sum_{q=0}^{10} \frac{(\widehat{w}_q^{(10)} - c_q)^2}{2q+1} + \sum_{q=11}^{Q_g} \frac{c_q^2}{2q+1}. \end{aligned}}$$

The framework already supplies $c_q = a_q/C_Q$; dividing by C_Q again would be incorrect. This error is against the clean fixed target, so no observation-noise variance is added. The normalization ensures $\mathbb{E}_{a,x}[g(x)^2] = 1$, not unit energy for every target draw.

Problem 3(c): Implementation, checks and protocol

Implementation. The fitting function uses least squares directly on the raw Legendre design. The population-error function pads only the degree axis with zeros and sums squared coefficient differences with weights $1/(2q+1)$. For a batch, it returns one risk for each column. Inputs are not modified and targets are not normalized again.

Fitting verification. Use x_i as 40 equally spaced points from -0.95 to 0.95 and noiseless labels $y_i = 0.3L_0(x_i) - 0.7L_1(x_i) + 0.2L_2(x_i)$. The expected degree-2 coefficients are $(0.3, -0.7, 0.2)$; degree 10 has the same first three coefficients and eight zeros. Actual fitted coefficients are:

Degree index	Expected	Computed $K = 2$	Computed $K = 10$
0	0.3	0.3000000000000000	0.2999999999999975
1	-0.7	-0.7000000000000001	-0.7000000000000006
2	0.2	0.2000000000000012	0.1999999999999998
3	0	–	4.040781×10^{-16}
4	0	–	$-5.334285 \times 10^{-16}$
5	0	–	2.982244×10^{-16}
6	0	–	$-5.642959 \times 10^{-16}$
7	0	–	2.632139×10^{-16}
8	0	–	$-2.322173 \times 10^{-16}$
9	0	–	2.163094×10^{-16}
10	0	–	$-1.798246 \times 10^{-16}$

The largest coefficient differences are 1.221×10^{-15} ($K = 2$) and 2.498×10^{-15} ($K = 10$), below 10^{-11}. The expected clean-target risk is zero; the computed risks are 3.024×10^{-31} and 6.495×10^{-30}. Recovery checks the fitting function without noise or missing target terms.

Error verification. Use model coefficients $w = (0.5, -0.3, 0.2)$ and an already-normalized target $c = (0.1, 0.2, -0.1, 0.4)$. The expected error is

$$0.4^2 + \frac{(-0.5)^2}{3} + \frac{0.3^2}{5} + \frac{(-0.4)^2}{7} = 0.2841904761904762.$$

The implemented analytic result is 0.2841904761904762. Independent 80-point Gauss–Legendre quadrature of $(f-g)^2/2$ gives 0.28419047619047905, a difference of 2.831×10^{-15}, below 10^{-10}. This compares evaluation in input space with the coefficient formula, including the missing degree-3 term and the uniform density. Additional scalar checks give expected/computed values $1/1$ for constant residual one, $4/7$ / $4/7$ for a target-only tail, and $9/5$ / $9/5$ for a model-only tail. All eight supplied P3 tests and batched-column checks passed.

Fixed full experiment. The two original grids were run with seed 666 and 1000 independent trial rows per cell. Each pair of models fits exactly the same labels. Across cells, the provided random bank reuses input/coefficient prefixes and noise to form paired comparisons. Each cell reports the arithmetic mean of all 1000 values of $\rho_e = E_{\text{out}}(f_{10}) - E_{\text{out}}(f_2)$. No trial was discarded, no regularization was added, and no numerical error was clipped or smoothed. Across all fits, the recorded maximum violation of $E_{\text{in}}(f_{10}) \leq E_{\text{in}}(f_2)$ was 0.

Problem 3(c): Required heat maps

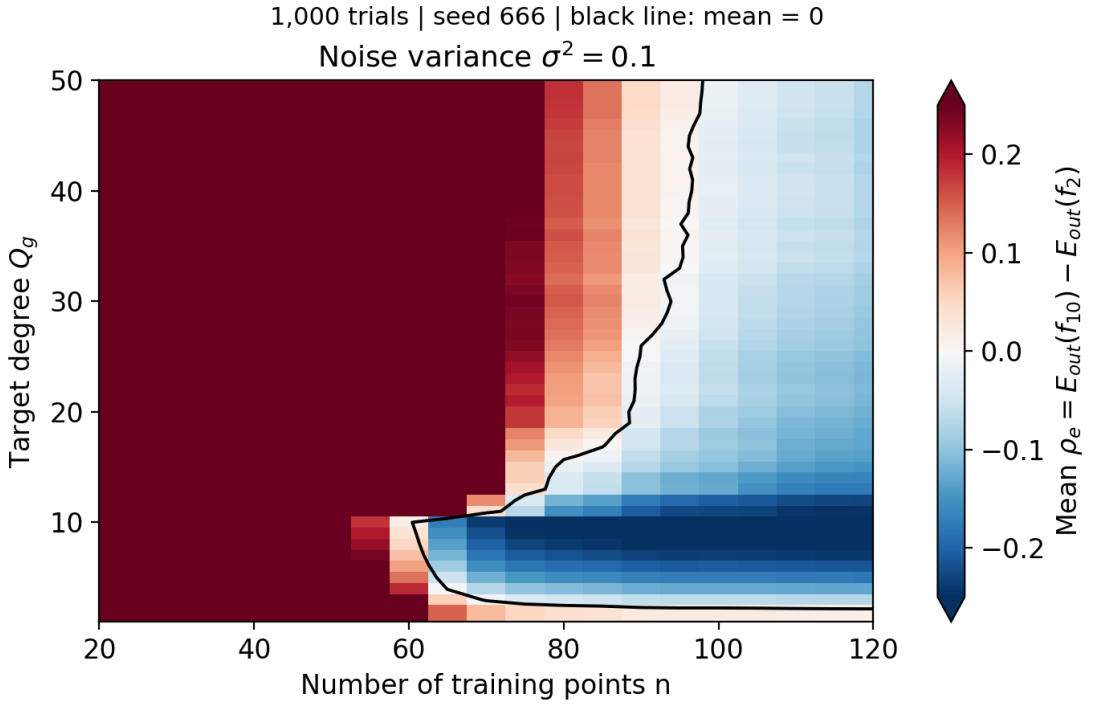


Figure 5: Target-complexity grid at fixed $\sigma^2 = 0.1$: horizontal axis $n = 20, 25, \ldots, 120$, vertical axis $Q_g = 1, \ldots, 50$. Each cell averages all 1000 trials.

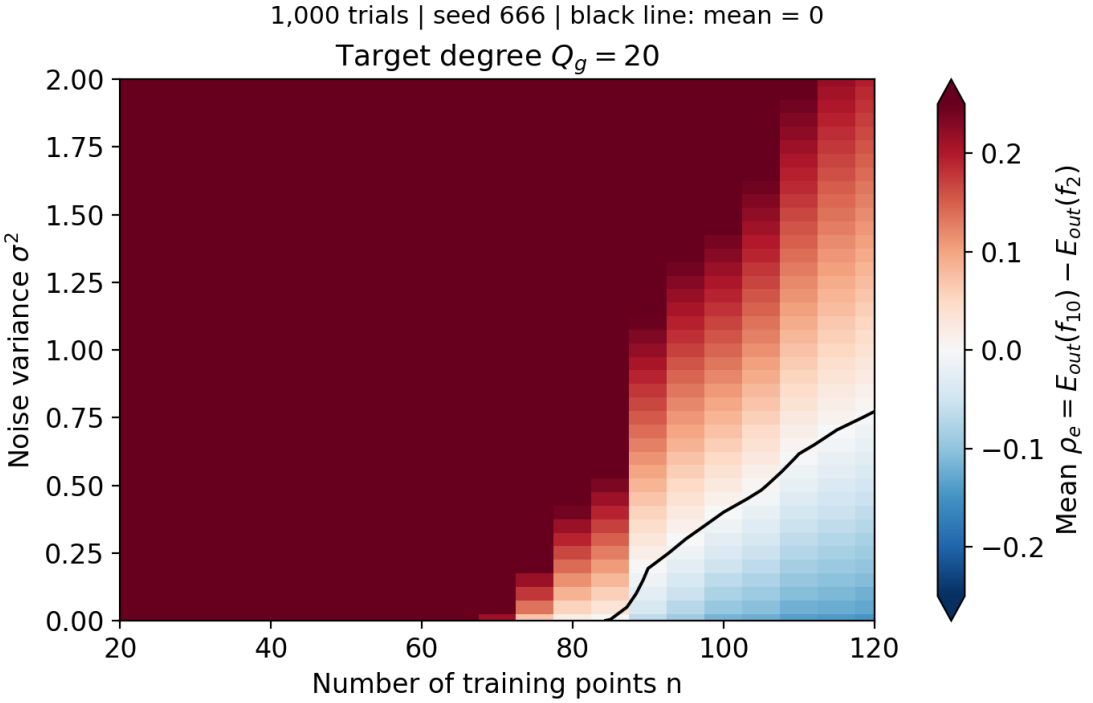


Figure 6: Noise-variance grid at fixed $Q_g = 20$: the same horizontal sample counts and vertical axis $\sigma^2 = 0, 0.05, \ldots, 2$.

Problem 3(c): Interpretation

Colors and the zero contour. Red means positive mean ρ_e: the degree-10 model has a larger clean-target error than the degree-2 model despite having no larger optimal training error. Blue means negative mean ρ_e, so degree 10 generalizes better in this particular comparison. White is near zero and the black contour marks the empirical zero-mean boundary. A negative value does not prove the degree-10 model cannot overfit relative to another model.

Colors saturate at ± 0.25 for visibility. The actual complexity-grid means range from -0.296410 to 1.032363×10^6, and noise-grid means from -0.146917 to 4.812316×10^6. These values were not clipped. Some finite-sample Legendre designs are poorly conditioned: the smallest recorded degree-10 design singular value is 1.304×10^{-5}. Large fitted coefficients can therefore amplify noise or model misspecification into large population errors, particularly where sample coverage is poor. All trials, including these extreme ones, contribute to the required arithmetic mean.

Sample count. More observations generally reduce the estimation instability of the flexible model in the observed grids and allow its approximation advantage to emerge. For example, at $Q_g = 20$, $\sigma^2 = 0.1$, the mean error difference changes from about 968028.958439 at $n = 20$, to 11.581522 at $n = 40$, to 2.483317 at $n = 60$, and to -0.119340 at $n = 120$. At $n = 120$, the mean risks are 0.409165 for degree 2 and 0.289825 for degree 10. This is an observed tendency, not a theorem of monotonicity for each sample or every grid cell.

Noise variance. Noise can be fitted by the extra coefficients of f_{10} and increase estimation variance. At $Q_g = 20, n = 120$, the means below move from a degree-10 advantage to a disadvantage as noise increases:

σ^2	0	0.1	1	2
Mean ρ_e	-0.146917	-0.119340	0.037381	0.196897

Finite paired Monte Carlo estimates need not be monotone at every cell. For example, at $n = 40$ the zero-noise mean is 11.665551 and the variance-0.1 mean is 11.581522. Sample-specific cross terms can make such local comparisons nonmonotone; they are not grounds for discarding trials or changing the prescribed mean.

Target complexity. Increasing Q_g is not always harmful. At $\sigma^2 = 0.1, n = 120$, the mean ρ_e is 0.014199 for $Q_g = 1$, -0.071197 for $Q_g = 3$, -0.296410 for $Q_g = 10$, and -0.119340 for $Q_g = 20$. For targets of degree at most 2, both model classes contain the target and the extra coefficients mainly add noise-fitting variance. For intermediate degrees up to 10, the larger model can represent structure that the quadratic omits. Above degree 10, both models are misspecified; estimation error, omitted high-order components and the degree-dependent target normalization all matter. Consequently target degree alone does not determine the relative error.

Can positive relative overfitting occur without observation noise? Yes. The noise-grid mean at $\sigma^2 = 0, Q_g = 20, n = 20$ is $558740.582041 > 0$, whereas at $n = 120$ it is -0.146917. With degree 20 the target is outside both fitted model classes, and fitting its values at a limited random set of inputs can induce a poor degree-10 approximation elsewhere, especially when the design is ill-conditioned. Observation noise is therefore not necessary. If the noiseless target were contained in the degree-10 class and the design had full column rank, an exact fit would instead recover it in exact arithmetic; this positive-error argument concerns the misspecified target case.

Limits of the contour. The displayed boundary is an empirical comparison of two models under this fixed random bank. The grids share random numbers, so adjacent cells are paired rather than independent. Within each cell there are 1000 independent trials, but rare large errors can strongly affect the mean: at $Q_g = 20, \sigma^2 = 0.1, n = 20$, its standard error is about 498426.190234. The black line is not evidence of a universal sharp transition, nor a guarantee about an individual fitted model.

Execution and assistance disclosure

The fixed experiments were actually executed on 27 October 2026 using Python 3.12.14, NumPy 2.2.6, SciPy 1.15.3, scikit-learn 1.7.2, Matplotlib 3.10.6 and threadpoolctl 3.7.0, on a CPU with numerical-library thread count limited to one by the original frameworks. The source functions, verification scripts, original runners/frameworks/tests and dependency list accompany this PDF. The small verification scripts require no datasets. Digits is included in scikit-learn; Dry Bean is downloaded from the fixed UCI URL and checked against the teacher's SHA-256. Data and raw trial archives are excluded from the submission as instructed.

Codex assisted with mathematical derivation, numerical implementation, test execution, experiment execution and English drafting. The dedicated AI page records the actual student–Codex verification question and numerical follow-up, translated from Chinese into English, with the source of the numerical evidence identified. Earlier coordinating-agent/coding-agent exchanges are also retained locally. Separate agents performed technical verification and final package review. The student remains responsible for understanding the submitted work and expressing mathematical derivations and explanations in their own words, as required by the assignment. This AI-assisted draft does not establish that a personal wording review has already occurred.